HANDLE WITH CAUTION

Not many in India are concerned about Trump's disruptive presidency; with China, they prefer circumspection. The government's overall foreign policy gets a thumbs up, though not the ties with neighbours

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ALLIES GOING STRONG US President Donald Trump with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi, February 25, 2020

No one was in any doubt that Donald Trump would keep his word at the start of his second presidency. What's taken everyone aback is the speed at which he is implementing his agenda. As the world adjusts to the new reality—of sweeping tariffs on imports, the US pulling out of WHO, USAID funds frozen and illegal immigrants deported—PM Narendra Modi met the US president in Washington D.C. on February 12-13 to discuss trade, tariffs and the next steps in the US-India strategic partnership. Respondents in the India Today Mood of the Nation (MOTN) February 2025 poll are divided over what the Trump presidency will mean for India. While 30 per cent say it will be good for India, 31.7 per cent say it would have little impact. Around 16 per cent think it does no bode well for India.

Closer home, India is keenly monitoring the turmoil in Bangladesh ever since the ouster of prime minister Sheikh Hasina in August 2024. Foreign secretary Vikram Misri's visit to Dhaka in December was an indication of New Delhi recalibrating its diplomatic approach and engaging cautiously with the interim government. Repeated calls for Hasina's extradition to Bangladesh and attacks on minorities, especially Hindus, have been a thorn in ties, but New Delhi is emphasising non-interference. MOTN respondents have a mixed reaction to this approach. While 20.6 per cent believe it to be sensible, over 33 per cent say New Delhi did not react strongly enough to Hindus being targeted. On India sheltering Hasina, 37.6 per cent say it is the right thing to do since she was a steadfast ally; 21.1 per cent feel she should be extradited to improve ties. Over 29 per cent say she should be asked to move to another country.

With tension in Eastern Ladakh at a low ebb now, New Delhi and Beijing have been gradually mending ties. On what should be India's priority in managing relations with China, over 53 per cent of MOTN respondents believe in strengthening border security, while 19.7 per cent favour enhancing trade ties. More than 23 per cent feel India should pursue diplomatic dialogues with Beijing.

As always, India has been maintain-

Q. How do you think India's relationship with neighbours has been in recent times?

